

NAME:

STUDENT #:

Sustainability

Read the scenario below and answer the following questions.

Scenario: EcoPlast Packaging and the Sustainability Dilemma

EcoPlast Inc. is a packaging manufacturer that supplies plastic containers to major food companies. With growing public concern about plastic waste and environmental harm, EcoPlast launched a new line of biodegradable food containers made from corn-based polylactic acid (PLA).

While the launch was initially celebrated, challenges quickly emerged:

- Customers complained that containers became brittle when stored in colder conditions and warped under heat.
- Some recycling facilities reported that mixing PLA with traditional plastics caused contamination, making recycling batches unusable.
- Consumer research showed that people supported eco-friendly products, but expected the same durability and performance as regular plastic.

Meanwhile, environmental groups praised EcoPlast for taking a step toward sustainability but argued that the company's products were more of a "green marketing" move than a truly effective solution, since the containers often ended up in landfills where they did not properly biodegrade.

EcoPlast defended itself by arguing that:

- They responded to consumer demand for sustainable products.
- Their labeling clearly stated the limitations of PLA containers.
- Rapid market competition forced them to release the product quickly.

Regulators are now questioning whether EcoPlast adequately tested product performance and whether companies should be allowed to market products as "sustainable" if they do not meet consumer expectations or achieve significant environmental benefits.

Answer the following questions:

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1. Were consumers partly liable for their dissatisfaction because they had unrealistic expectations of biodegradable packaging?

Answer: Consumers may share partial responsibility, as many did not fully understand the performance limitations of PLA. However, the company had a duty to clearly manage expectations.

2. Was EcoPlast liable for the failures of its containers because the company released them without sufficient performance testing?

Answer: Yes. EcoPlast has a responsibility to ensure proper testing before releasing products. Rushing to market compromised quality and consumer trust.

3. Should EcoPlast continue selling the containers, knowing that they may not perform reliably in real-world conditions?

Answer: Not without modifications. Continuing as-is risks legal liability and reputational damage. Improving durability or redesigning the product is essential.

4. Should EcoPlast stop marketing the containers as “sustainable” until better evidence of environmental benefit is available?

Answer: Yes. Marketing them as fully sustainable is misleading if biodegradability only works in ideal conditions and not in landfills.

5. Can consumers or regulators make a claim of negligence or misleading marketing against EcoPlast?

Answer: Yes. Claims could be based on negligence for inadequate testing or misrepresentation if sustainability claims cannot be substantiated.

6. Was it unreasonably risky for EcoPlast to release a product that compromised durability for the sake of sustainability?

Answer: Yes. Products that fail in real-world use cause waste, harm consumer trust, and undermine the very purpose of sustainability.

7. Should the containers have included stronger warnings, cautions, or danger labels (e.g., “Not suitable for hot liquids”)? Which is most appropriate, and why?

Answer: A caution label would be appropriate, specifying limitations such as temperature and handling. Danger labels are excessive, but clear cautions could prevent misuse.

8. If you worked at EcoPlast and wanted to prevent such issues in the future, what changes would you make in product design, testing, or consumer communication?

Answer: I would improve R&D and product testing, adopt clear labeling, educate consumers on proper disposal, and ensure performance matches consumer expectations before launch.